Determining Your Coaching Objectives

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching,* 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024), 14-23.

Coaches can design or choose from many objectives to include within their coaching philosophies. However, most coaching objectives usually fall into the following three broad categories:

1. To win
2. To help young people have fun or enjoy their experiences
3. To help young people develop . . .
    - *physically,* by learning and developing sport skills, and improving physical fitness;
    - *mentally,* by learning to focus, manage their emotions, cope with adversity, and feel competent and worthy; and
    - *socially,* by learning to communicate and cooperate effectively with teammates, opponents, officials, and coaches.

Which of these objectives are important to you? Perhaps you believe all three are worthwhile. But are they equally important? What if you must choose between them, which at times you will? Coaches often must decide whether to pursue victory at the possible expense of an athlete's well-being or long-term development. What will your priorities be then?

Assessing Your Objectives

Complete form 2.1 to help you decide on your objectives for winning, having fun, and helping young athletes develop physically, mentally, and socially.

FORM 2.1

Your Coaching Objectives

Instructions:

1. Read each statement and the three options that follow.
2. Decide which of the three options you believe is most important and write the numeral 3 in the white box next to that option.
3. Then decide which option is least important to you and write the numeral 1 in the corresponding white box.
4. Put a 2 in the remaining white box.
5. Add up the scores for each column and write the totals in the Total Score boxes.

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6. Although in some cases you may think all three choices are important, indicate which is the *most* important and which is the *least* important of the three. Try to answer each question as honestly as possible.

The best coaches are those who . . .			
a. give individual help and are interested in their athletes' development.			
b. make practices and games enjoyable.			
c. teach athletes the skills needed to win.			
If a news story were written about me, I would like to be described as . . .			
a. a coach who contributed to the development of young people.			
b. a coach for whom athletes enjoyed playing.			
c. a winning coach.			
As a coach I emphasize . . .			
a. developing athletes' skills.			
b. enjoying the sport.			
c. winning.			
Total score			
	Development	**Fun**	**Winning**

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching*, 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024).

Consider your total scores for the objectives. Each total should be between 3 and 9. The higher the total, the more you emphasize that outcome. The first column shows your priority for the development of young athletes, the second is your priority for your athletes to enjoy their sport experience, and the third is the importance you give to winning.

Most coaches' scores indicate that they believe winning is least important and helping athletes develop physically, mentally, and socially is most important. Did you answer the same way? Of course, it's the "right thing to say," and it's easy to say in a questionnaire like this. But are your scores indicative of how you coach? Do you really believe that winning is the least important of the three objectives?

Nothing is more important in determining how you coach than the significance you give to winning. Some coaches who say winning is least important don't behave that way when they coach. For example, coaches who play only their best athletes, who play injured athletes, or who scream disparagingly at athletes who have erred demonstrate that winning is more important to them than their athletes' development.

Do you at times overemphasize winning? Do you at times make decisions that reflect more concern about winning the game than the development of your athletes? It is easy to do in a culture that places so much value on winning.

Consequences of Overemphasizing Winning

Let's deal with the elephant in the room and be frank about winning. You may be reading this and thinking, "Of course it's about winning—that's the whole point of sport." Or "We have to teach kids how to be competitive and win." Or "Winning rocks, and I love to win." We definitely agree with you on the last point! Winning does rock, as we've all experienced the heady exhilaration of winning a hard-fought competition. Coaches should want to win, seek to win, and train their athletes to compete to win. However, it is a mistake to emphasize winning to the detriment of the other two key coaching objectives in youth sport.

Overemphasizing Winning Is Detrimental to Skill Development

The most negative consequence of an overemphasis on winning is that it interferes *with skill development and the long-term performance and development of athletes*. Top coaches and sport scientists certainly agree on this point (e.g., Vealey & Chase, 2016). Consider these examples:

- The coach tells the tee ball pitcher if she fields a grounder, to run the ball to first base because the first base player is not good at catching the ball.
- A boy short in stature is coached to take several pitches to try to earn a walk to get on base, as opposed to using his skills to swing the bat and try to get a hit.
- A soccer team is coached to kick the ball over the top to the fastest player, so she can score (instead of teaching technical skills like passing out the back or the goalie rolling the ball to a teammate to start the play upfield).
- An early-maturing 11-year-old girl who is much taller than her teammates or opponents is used only as a post player (close to the basket) by her 7th grade basketball coach and not taught perimeter skills such as outside shooting and ball handling. This allows the coach to win more games, but limits the development of the athlete as a complete basketball player. She doesn't grow any taller, and fails to make her high school team because she lacks needed guard skills to play on the perimeter.

The young athletes who are better than their peers prior to puberty often are not the better athletes after maturation. Thus, if coaches ignore the less mature athletes who can't help them win in the short-term, they are neglecting to develop the talents of athletes who could go on to have outstanding skills in the long-term. This partly explains why 70 percent of young athletes drop out of youth sport by age 13 (Miner, 2016). If athletes' individual skill development is not a priority for the coach, the athletes become bored, fail to improve, and often drop out.

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Overemphasizing Winning Can Lead to Unethical Coaching Practices

Along with hampering skill development, coaches' mentality of winning at all costs often leads to unethical decisions such as playing injured athletes, advocating the use of performance-enhancing drugs, and cheating to win. When the star running back at Cardinal Ritter High School in Missouri was suspended during the last game of 2018, his coaches gave him a fake name and a new uniform number so he could play in disguise in the 2019 season opener (Mantucca, 2019). When the flagrant eligibility violation came to light later in the season, all wins were forfeited, and the entire coaching staff was fired. You may be thinking that you would never do such a ridiculous thing, yet when coaches develop the mentality that they must win, it is often a slippery slope in terms of making unethical decisions around the rules of the game.

Focusing on Winning Distracts Athletes From the Process of Performing

Ironically, an overemphasis on winning is detrimental to winning! Research has overwhelmingly shown that present moment focus on the *process* of performing is the mental state needed for peak performance in sport (e.g., Anderson et al., 2014). Expecting a certain outcome, such as winning, interferes with this needed present moment focus. Prior to competition, coaches should help athletes adopt a simple and clear focus on individual goals and their job for that performance, which they have learned in practice.

Overemphasizing Winning Can Jeopardize Coaches' Self-Esteem

Your coaching success is about more than just winning. It's such an important point that it merits attention again. Coaches who base their self-esteem on whether their teams win face tremendous pressure and harmful personal outcomes such as burnout and feelings of worthlessness. Your worthiness as a person is not dependent upon outcomes over which you have little control, such as wins and losses. Consider the following case:

Coach Perez's 8th grade softball team lacked talent this year, because it was a newer sport in the community and none of the girls on the team had played club softball. In particular, there were no players with any pitching experience. They failed to win a game the entire season, and scored very few runs. The team was outmatched from the start by schools that had better players with experience in club softball. Coach Perez focused on teaching skills and individual and team improvement, and tried to help the players enjoy learning softball despite the many team losses. They did improve and liked the game, and several players signed up for club softball the next summer.

What if Coach Perez's self-esteem had been tied to winning? She would have had a miserable season, and could have questioned whether she should continue coaching. Genuine self-esteem is not something you gain from winning. Rather, self-esteem is gained by living up to your own personal standards and values. You put those standards

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and values in action by pursuing coaching objectives related to athlete development and overall success. Yes, we understand that it feels exhilarating to win because we're competitive people and we love sport and competing. However, coaches should work to stay true to their multiple coaching objectives, and push back against unrealistic societal expectations to win all the time.

Balancing the Three Coaching Objectives

Is it possible for coaches to pursue all three objectives of athlete development, enjoyment, and winning, and is this really the best thing for youth athletes? It is understandable that coaches face powerful social norms to emphasize win-ning and that coaches' jobs sometimes depend on win–loss records. However, coaches who focus on skill development are rewarded with a greater commitment by their athletes resulting in *greater improvement in performance* as compared to coaches who focus on winning (Hall et al., 2017). Moreover, there are successful coaches at all levels who seek balance in their coaching objectives.

Examples of Balancing Objectives

Notice that the coaching objectives of development, enjoyment, and winning are all included in the United Local High School Boys Soccer Program box. Their website demonstrates the program's emphasis on all three objectives. Mike Matheny's coaching objectives for his club baseball team were (1) teach the boys how to play baseball the right way, (2) make a positive impact on them as young men, and (3) do all of this with class (Matheny & Jenkins, 2015).

United Local High School Boys Soccer Program: Coaching Objectives

Establishing coaching objectives sets the tone for a positive athlete experience. Following are 5 of the 12 coaching and staff goals and objectives of the United Local High School Boys Soccer Program in Hanoverton, Ohio. Note how the coaching objectives for this soccer program balance winning, development, and enjoyment.

1. To cultivate a fun and challenging player-centered learning environment that encourages player and team development
2. To hold coaching staff and players accountable to the highest standards of sportsmanship
3. To foster the technical, tactical, physical, and psychosocial development of each player
4. To foster a lifelong love and passion for the "beautiful game" within each player
5. To commit to upholding the winning tradition of this program

Patty Gasso, head coach of the University of Oklahoma softball program, has led her teams to four NCAA national championships. However, in an article titled "How I Got Here: Patty Gasso Is a Champion Who Doesn't Focus on Championships" (Collington,

2017), Coach Gasso explained how she learned to balance her coaching objectives to keep winning in perspective:

> *I put a lot of pressure on myself to win at all costs. It was after the [first] 2000 national championship. No one expected us to do that. And then we did it. Everything changed for me. My expectation was we would do it every year. But it doesn't work like that. I was becoming someone that I didn't like. . . . The answer was this is not about winning games. It's about changing lives and saving souls. You are not there to win at all costs. It was hard to trust that. My job relies on winning. But I surrendered. I started diving more into the internal side of these athletes . . . I would probably say in 2012 I really felt that this is how I'm supposed to do it. And I've stuck with it ever since . . . I learned to care more about my athletes first and winning second. Life is hard, and I want them to know they can handle anything, and a softball field is a good place to practice that.*

Willie Cromack, a volunteer youth soccer coach from Vancouver (Canada) designed a clever way to broaden the focus of coaches and athletes beyond winning by changing the reward structure. He created Play Better (goplaybetter.com), an initiative in which teams' developmental performance achievements can result in financial contributions to charitable initiatives. Teams set their own specific goals at the start of the season, such as trying stepover moves on the field, completing 100 passes, or playing back to the goalkeeper 20 times. Each team chooses a charity or cause they want to support, such as cancer research, animal shelters, homelessness, bullying, or after-school initiatives. As the team achieves each goal, supporters of the team then contribute financially to the team's charity of choice.

The goals are set up to be meaningful technical developments that directly relate to becoming better players. Coach Cromack noticed that teams started playing better without ever speaking about winning. He stated: "Winning simply finds its rightful place in their brains; important, but not more important than the world and their own development" (O'Sullivan, 2014).

Should Fun Really Be a Coaching Objective?

Multiple research studies over the past three decades have repeatedly shown that "to have fun" is the main reason kids aged 5 to 17 participate in sport. However, some coaches argue that frivolous fun distracts from the focus and effort needed to develop skills and practice team strategies, and that it's not an important coaching objective. We see their point, and think it's useful to understand the difference between fun and enjoyment.

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Fun, as a lighthearted experience of pleasure, certainly has a place in youth sport. But sometimes it is emphasized too much, and kids get the wrong idea that they should be experiencing fun at every moment. The goal of continuous fun is impossible and unhealthy and is not a good objective for youth sport. Perhaps enjoyment and instilling a love of sport is a better way to focus on this objective. Coaches should build in a few drills and activities that are fun, along with activities that require the focused effort and concentration essential in learning and skill development. As young athletes mature, they will experience the enjoyment and satisfaction that is part of putting forth great effort to accomplish meaningful goals (Shields & Bredemeier, 2009).

Clarify and Stay True to Program Objectives

Sport programs vary in the emphasis placed on development, enjoyment, and winning. Most *community-based recreational sport* programs emphasize fun, skill development, and participation by all. *School sports* often involve selection (meaning that some athletes are excluded in tryouts or sit the bench), thus they typically are more competitive, and the objective of winning is emphasized more. *Club sports* (also called select or travel sports) are even more selective than school programs, and emphasize more intensive skill development, travel, significant participation fees, and emphasis on winning.

Problems emerge when coaches at the recreational level (e.g., entry-level youth sport) emphasize winning by playing the most talented athletes or making practices grueling and overly serious. Such ill-fitting objectives are incompatible with the reasons that children and parents seek out community-based recreational teams for enjoyment and skill development. This incompatibility also occurs when coaches in school or club programs pursue recreational objectives, although this occurs much less frequently.

The objectives for each sport program should be explicit and clear for coaches, athletes, parents, and guardians. This is particularly critical in today's youth sport culture, with the increase in club sports and entrepreneurial programs offered outside of schools. Athletes and parents should be provided answers to the following questions:

- How much is individual skill development emphasized in the program?
- How is skill development balanced with the pursuit of winning?
- How is playing time allotted?
- How much practice time and travel are required?
- What does a typical practice look like?

As coaches, you should also clarify program objectives with your program director to ensure that you are fulfilling the objectives designed for that program. If you feel that your coaching objectives are incompatible with the stated objectives for a program, you should not agree to serve as coach in that situation. In addition, you should provide the athletes on your team and their parents or guardians a list or explanation of the

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objectives for your program so everyone is clear about the focus of your program. Overall, we recommend that the long-term objective of helping athletes develop should remain the first priority in all types of programs.

Summary on Balancing the Three Objectives

We understand that fans cheer winning teams and criticize teams with losses, winning sport programs receive more funding than losing ones, and coaches' jobs sometimes depend on win–loss records. As powerful as the urge to prioritize winning over other objectives is, we urge you not to do so. Instead, we hope you'll strive to coach to achieve all three objectives, while keeping in mind that the development of your athletes is your foremost priority. Like Coach Patty Gasso and others have realized, as you coach for development, you'll find that winning falls into place.



Coach Patty Gasso focuses on her athletes' development and enjoyment, along with winning.

C. Morgan Engel/NCAA Photos via Getty Images.

Athletes First, Winning Second

To help you maintain the perspective and balance needed among the three coaching objectives presented in this chapter, we offer a simple philosophy statement: "Athletes First, Winning Second." This philosophy clarifies that winning is an important objective, but that athlete development and well-being is always the most important objective. We are hopeful that the coaching philosophy that you develop incorporates the spirit of "Athletes First, Winning Second" (figure 2.1).

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FIGURE 2.1 It might seem counterintuitive, but this is a winning philosophy.

What these four words mean is this: Every decision you make and every behavior you display should be based first on what you judge is best for your athletes, and second on what may improve the athlete's or team's chances of winning.

Athletes first, winning second is the philosophical foundation for the Bill of Rights for Young Athletes (figure 2.2). Take a moment to review these rights. Even though they were written for younger children, these rights apply to athletes of all ages. Consider how your coaching might deny an athlete these rights. Then consider how you can coach to help ensure that each athlete enjoys these rights.

Having athletes first, winning second as your objective does not mean that winning is unimportant. The immediate short-term objective of any contest is to win. Striving to win within the rules of the game should be every athlete's and coach's objective. To play sports without striving to win would be dishonest and diminish the joy of playing sports.

The quote "Winning isn't everything; it's the only thing," is sometimes attributed to Hall of Fame professional football coach Vince Lombardi. However, Lombardi clarified his quote to be "Winning isn't everything, but striving to win is" (https://www.azquotes.com/quote/911223). Near the end of his life, he emphasized the importance of *striving* to win over a win-at-all-costs mentality by saying, "I wished I'd never said the thing [original quote] . . . I meant the effort. I meant having a goal. I sure didn't mean for people to crush human values and morality" (as cited in Austin, 2010).

A coach's emphasis on winning should not be on the winning itself, but empowering athletes to strive to win. It's the pursuit of the victory, the dream of achieving the goal, more than the goal itself that yields the joy of sport. Many outstanding athletes candidly say that their best memories of sport are not the victories themselves but the months of preparation and anticipation and the self-revelation they received before and during the competition.

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Remember that striving to win is an important objective of any contest, but it is not the most important objective of sport participation. It is easy to lose sight of the long-term objectives— helping athletes develop physically, mentally, and socially—while pursuing the short-term objective of winning the contest because the rewards for winning are immediate and powerful. Ask yourself: Will I be able to keep these long-term objectives in sight not only during practice but in the heat of a contest, not only when I am winning but when I'm losing, and not only when I have the support of my administrator but when that person is pressuring me to win?

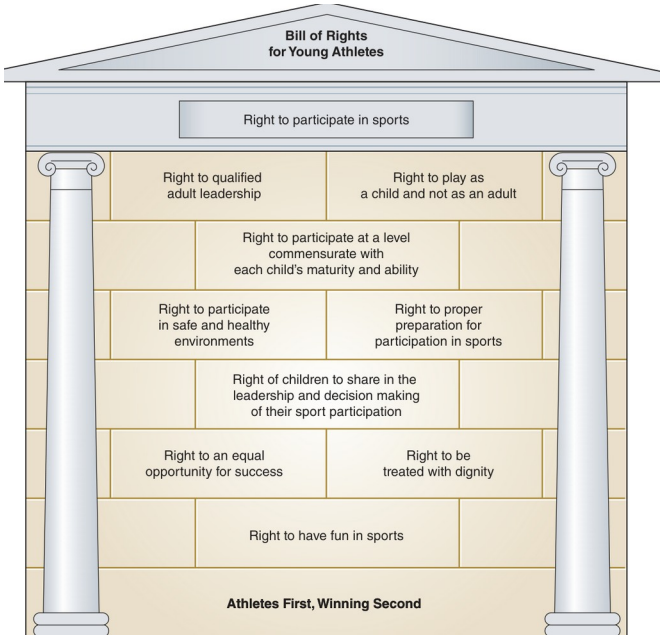


FIGURE 2.2 Building a winning coaching philosophy.

Reprinted by permission from *Guidelines for Children's Sports* (Reston, VA: National Association for Sport and Physical Education, 1979).

Figure 2.2 — Text in diagram

Bill of Rights for Young Athletes	
Right to participate in sports	
Right to qualified adult leadership	Right to play as a child and not as an adult
Right to participate at a level commensurate with each child's maturity and ability	
Right to participate in safe and healthy environments	Right to proper preparation for participation in sports
Right of children to share in the leadership and decision making of their sport participation	
Right to an equal opportunity for success	Right to be treated with dignity
Right to have fun in sports	
Athletes First, Winning Second	

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Your Personal Reasons for Coaching

Like other coaches, you probably have several personal reasons for why you coach. These reasons, of course, strongly influence and often turn into your coaching objectives. To examine your personal reasons for coaching, complete form 2.2.

FORM 2.2

Personal Reasons for Coaching

Instructions

1. Read all of the reasons first before evaluating how important these reasons are to you.
2. Add any other reasons that you have in the spaces provided.
3. Rate how important each reason is to you by placing a mark in the appropriate box.

	IMPORTANCE		
Reason	**Not at all**	**Somewhat**	**Very**
1. To be involved in a sport I like			
2. To earn a living			
3. To gain status in my community			
4. To have power			
5. To be with people I like			
6. To give something back to the sport			
7. To gain public recognition			
8. To enjoy myself			
9. To demonstrate my knowledge and skill in the sport			
10. To make up for the fact that I was not a good athlete			
11. To travel			
12. To help athletes develop physically, mentally, and socially			
13.			
14.			
15.			

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, Successful Coaching, 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024).

From Human Kinetics Coach Education, *Coaching Flag Football Principles Online Course* (Human Kinetics, 2027). Reprinted by permission from R. Martens, *Successful Coaching*, 5th ed. (Human Kinetics, 2024).

Look at the reasons and your rating of each and consider whether a conflict exists between your personal reasons for coaching and the objective of helping athletes develop physical, mental, and social skills. For example, if personal recognition or power is among your personal reasons for coaching, you will need to guard against placing this objective above the interests of your athletes. During intense competition, you will be vulnerable to pursuing your own goals of recognition and power at the expense of your athletes. This risk can be managed, but you must know yourself well and entrench firmly in your mind the philosophy of "Athletes First, Winning Second."

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